

VOCABULARY · CULTURE · ACTIVITIES

LEO MESSI

La historia del Diez

The football words every Spanish speaker uses, told through the boy from Rosario, with Spain 🇪🇸 and Argentina 🇦🇷 vocabulary

PONCHO
SPANISH

¡HOLA!

A small, quiet boy from a neighbourhood in Rosario got on a plane at thirteen with a bag and a left foot, and ended up lifting the World Cup in front of his whole country.

This resource collects more than 80 football words and expressions, each one with a real example sentence: the ball, the pitch, the positions, the trophies, training, and the night Argentina won the World Cup in 2022.

Football is the easiest way into Spanish there is, because you already know what's happening. And it's the vocabulary that changes most between Spain and Argentina, so you get two words for almost everything. At the end you'll find activities to check what you remember, and all the answers.

How to use it

1. **Read the word, then the sentence.** Words stick better when you see them in action.
2. **Watch a match in Spanish.** You'll catch more than you expect, especially the shouting.
3. **Learn both versions.** El balón in Madrid, la pelota in Buenos Aires.
4. **Try the activities** without looking back, then check the answers.

Two countries, two pitches

Football vocabulary changes more than almost any other. When you see two options, the first is common in Spain 🇪🇸 and the second in Argentina 🇦🇷. Both are completely normal football Spanish.

el campo 🇪🇸 = **la cancha** 🇦🇷

El Diez

In Spanish the shirt number works as a name: **el diez** is the team's creative player, the one who invents things. Messi has worn it for Barcelona, for Argentina and for Inter Miami.

el diez = **the number ten**

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01

UN NIÑO DE ROSARIO

A BOY FROM ROSARIO

Before the trophies: a small boy, a street and a ball.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el niño	the boy, the child	*De niño jugaba en la calle con sus hermanos.* As a boy he played in the street with his brothers.
Rosario	Rosario	*Nació en Rosario, en Argentina, en 1987.* He was born in Rosario, in Argentina, in 1987.
el barrio	the neighbourhood	*Su barrio se llama Las Heras.* His neighbourhood is called Las Heras.
la familia	the family	*Su familia lo acompañó siempre.* His family were always with him.
la abuela	the grandmother	*Su abuela Celia lo llevaba a entrenar.* His grandmother Celia used to take him to training.
el hermano	the brother	*Jugaba contra sus hermanos mayores.* He played against his older brothers.
pequeño / pequeña	small	*Era mucho más pequeño que los demás.* He was much smaller than the others.
crecer	to grow	*De niño necesitó un tratamiento para crecer.* As a child he needed treatment to grow.
el tratamiento	the treatment	*El tratamiento era muy caro.* The treatment was very expensive.
mudarse	to move house	*A los trece años se mudó a Barcelona.* At thirteen he moved to Barcelona.
la servilleta	the napkin	*El primer contrato se firmó en una servilleta.*

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01 · UN NIÑO DE ROSARIO

A BOY FROM ROSARIO

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la cantera 🇪🇸 las inferiores 🇦🇷	the youth academy	*Entró en la cantera del club.* He joined the club's youth academy.
el sueño	the dream	*Su sueño era jugar en primera.* His dream was to play in the first team.
zurdo / zurda	left-footed, left-handed	*Es zurdo, y se nota desde lejos.* He's left-footed, and you can tell from miles away.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Messi started at Newell's Old Boys in Rosario. When he was eleven doctors found he had a growth hormone deficiency, and the treatment cost more than his family could pay: that is why, at thirteen, the whole family moved to Barcelona.

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02

EL JUEGO

THE GAME

The words you need before you can say anything else.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el fútbol	football	*El fútbol se habla en todos los idiomas.* Football is spoken in every language.
el balón 🇪🇸 **la pelota** 🇦🇷	the ball	*Le dio al balón con la zurda.* He hit the ball with his left foot.
el partido	the match	*El partido empieza a las nueve.* The match starts at nine.
el equipo	the team	*Un equipo tiene once jugadores.* A team has eleven players.
el jugador / la jugadora	the player	*Es el jugador más bajito del campo.* He's the shortest player on the pitch.
el gol	the goal	*Marcó un gol en el minuto noventa.* He scored a goal in the ninetieth minute.
marcar	to score	*Marcó dos goles en la final.* He scored two goals in the final.
ganar	to win	*Ganamos tres a dos.* We won three two.
perder	to lose	*Perder también enseña.* Losing teaches you things too.
empatar	to draw	*Empataron a uno.* They drew one all.
el árbitro / la árbitra	the referee	*El árbitro pitó falta.* The referee blew for a foul.

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02 · EL JUEGO THE GAME

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el minuto	the minute	*Quedan cinco minutos.* There are five minutes left.
el tiempo	the half	*En el segundo tiempo cambió todo.* Everything changed in the second half.
chutar 🇪🇸 patear 🇦🇷	to shoot, to kick	*Chutó desde fuera del área.* He shot from outside the box.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

A football match in Spanish has dos tiempos (two halves) and el descanso or el entretiempo in between. If the score is level, there can be la prórroga (extra time) and then los penaltis, called los penales in Argentina.

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03

EN EL CAMPO

ON THE PITCH

Where everything happens, and who stands where.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el campo 🇪🇸 la cancha 🇦🇷	the pitch	*El campo estaba en perfectas condiciones.* The pitch was in perfect condition.
el césped 🇪🇸 el pasto 🇦🇷	the grass	*El césped está recién cortado.* The grass has just been cut.
la portería 🇪🇸 el arco 🇦🇷	the goal (posts)	*El balón entró por la escuadra de la portería.* The ball went in at the top corner of the goal.
el portero 🇪🇸 el arquero 🇦🇷	the goalkeeper	*El portero paró el penalti.* The goalkeeper saved the penalty.
el defensa	the defender	*Dos defensas no pudieron pararlo.* Two defenders couldn't stop him.
el centrocampista	the midfielder	*El centrocampista reparte el juego.* The midfielder spreads the play around.
el delantero	the forward, the striker	*Juega de delantero y de diez.* He plays as a forward and as a number ten.
el capitán / la capitana	the captain	*Fue capitán de Argentina.* He was captain of Argentina.
la camiseta	the shirt	*Su camiseta lleva el número diez.* His shirt has the number ten on it.
el pase	the pass	*Dio un pase imposible.* He played an impossible pass.
el regate 🇪🇸 la gambeta 🇦🇷	the dribble	*Su regate es inconfundible.* His dribbling is unmistakable.

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03 · EN EL CAMPO ON THE PITCH

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el tiro libre	the free kick	*Los tiros libres los tira él.* He takes the free kicks.
la falta	the foul	*Le hicieron falta en el área.* He was fouled in the box.
la tarjeta amarilla	the yellow card	*Vio una tarjeta amarilla.* He got a yellow card.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

A Spanish commentator shouts ¡GOOOOL! for as long as their breath lasts, and the habit started on the radio: before television, the length of the shout told listeners at home how important the goal was.

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04

LOS EQUIPOS Y LOS TÍTULOS

TEAMS AND TROPHIES

A career measured in cups, in three different countries.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el club	the club	*Jugó en el mismo club durante años.* He played at the same club for years.
el estadio	the stadium	*El estadio estaba lleno.* The stadium was full.
la liga	the league	*Ganó la liga española diez veces.* He won the Spanish league ten times.
la copa	the cup	*Levantó la copa con las dos manos.* He lifted the cup with both hands.
el título	the title	*Tiene más títulos que nadie.* He has more titles than anyone.
el trofeo	the trophy	*El trofeo es más pesado de lo que parece.* The trophy is heavier than it looks.
la final	the final	*La final se jugó en diciembre.* The final was played in December.
el Balón de Oro	the Ballon d'Or	*Ganó el Balón de Oro más veces que nadie.* He has won the Ballon d'Or more times than anyone.
el récord	the record	*Batió un récord detrás de otro.* He broke one record after another.
el goleador / la goleadora	the top scorer	*Es el máximo goleador de su selección.* He is his country's all-time top scorer.
el aficionado 🇪🇸 el hincha 🇦🇷	the fan	*Los hinchas cantaban su nombre.* The fans were singing his name.

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04 · LOS EQUIPOS Y LOS TÍTULOS TEAMS AND TROPHIES

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la afición 🇪🇸 la hinchada 🇦🇷	the supporters	*La hinchada no se sentó en noventa minutos.* The supporters didn't sit down for ninety minutes.
la bandera	the flag	*Las banderas celestes y blancas llenaban las gradas.* Light blue and white flags filled the stands.
celebrar	to celebrate	*Celebraron en la calle hasta el amanecer.* They celebrated in the street until dawn.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Messi has played for Barcelona, Paris Saint-Germain and Inter Miami, and he is Barcelona's all-time top scorer. He has won the Ballon d'Or, the prize for the best player in the world, more times than any other footballer in history.

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05

ENTRENAR Y MEJORAR

TRAINING AND GETTING BETTER

The boring part that makes the rest possible.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
entrenar	to train	*Entrena todos los días del año.* He trains every day of the year.
el entrenamiento	the training session	*El entrenamiento dura dos horas.* Training lasts two hours.
el entrenador 🇪🇸 el técnico 🇦🇷	the coach, the manager	*El entrenador le dio la cinta de capitán.* The coach gave him the captain's armband.
las botas 🇪🇸 los botines 🇦🇷	the boots	*Se ata las botas siempre igual.* He ties his boots the same way every time.
correr	to run	*Corre poco, pero corre donde hay que correr.* He runs little, but he runs where it matters.
practicar	to practise	*Practica los tiros libres solo.* He practises free kicks on his own.
mejorar	to improve	*Siempre quiso mejorar algo.* He always wanted to improve something.
el esfuerzo	the effort	*El talento sin esfuerzo no alcanza.* Talent without effort isn't enough.
la lesión	the injury	*Una lesión lo dejó fuera dos meses.* An injury kept him out for two months.
el compañero / la compañera	the teammate	*Sus compañeros lo buscan siempre.* His teammates always look for him.
el vestuario	the dressing room	*En el vestuario habla poco.* In the dressing room he says little.

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05 · ENTRENAR Y MEJORAR

TRAINING AND GETTING BETTER

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
tímido / tímida	shy	*Dicen que es muy tímido fuera del campo.* They say he's very shy off the pitch.
humilde	humble	*Es humilde cuando gana y cuando pierde.* He's humble when he wins and when he loses.
el equipo / el conjunto	the side, the team	*Sin equipo no se gana nada.* Without a team you win nothing.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

At Barcelona's academy, La Masia, the children are taught to play out from the back and to pass more than they dribble. Messi arrived there at thirteen and spent his teenage years learning that before he ever played for the first team.

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06

ARGENTINA Y EL MUNDIAL

ARGENTINA AND THE WORLD CUP

18 December 2022: the day a country stopped.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la selección	the national team	*La selección argentina es la albiceleste.* The Argentinian national team is the albiceleste.
el Mundial	the World Cup	*El Mundial se jugó en Catar en 2022.* The World Cup was played in Qatar in 2022.
la Copa del Mundo	the World Cup (trophy)	*Levantó la Copa del Mundo en diciembre.* He lifted the World Cup in December.
la Copa América	the Copa América	*Antes ganó la Copa América en 2021.* Before that he won the Copa América in 2021.
el penalti 🇪🇸 el penal 🇦🇷	the penalty	*La final se decidió en los penales.* The final was decided on penalties.
la tanda de penaltis	the penalty shoot-out	*La tanda de penaltis duró una eternidad.* The shoot-out lasted an eternity.
la prórroga 🇪🇸 el alargue 🇦🇷	extra time	*Marcó también en la prórroga.* He scored in extra time as well.
el himno	the anthem	*Cantaron el himno llorando.* They sang the anthem in tears.
celeste y blanco	light blue and white	*Todo el país se vistió de celeste y blanco.* The whole country dressed in light blue and white.
la gente	the people	*La gente salió a la calle.* People came out onto the street.
la plaza	the square	*Millones fueron a la plaza.* Millions went to the square.

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06 · ARGENTINA Y EL MUNDIAL

ARGENTINA AND THE WORLD CUP

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
gritar	to shout	*Gritamos hasta quedarnos sin voz.* We shouted until we lost our voices.
llorar	to cry	*Lloró mucha gente esa noche.* A lot of people cried that night.
la emoción	the emotion, the excitement	*Fue pura emoción de principio a fin.* It was pure emotion from start to finish.

¿Sabías que...?

Argentina beat France in the 2022 World Cup final on 18 December. Messi scored twice, the match finished 3–3 and Argentina won on penalties. He was given the Golden Ball as the best player of the tournament, and millions of people filled the streets of Buenos Aires.

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07

FRASES DE FÚTBOL

FOOTBALL PHRASES

Short sentences you could really shout. When there are two versions, the second is how you'd say it in Argentina.

¿Quién juega hoy?
Who's playing today?

¿A qué hora es el partido?
What time is the match?

¿Cómo van?
What's the score?

Van dos a uno.
It's two one.

¡Vamos!
Come on!

¡Qué golazo!
What a goal!

Pásamela. / Pasámela.
Pass it to me.

¡Eso es falta!
That's a foul!

Juego de portero. / Juego de arquero.
I play in goal.

¿De qué equipo eres? / ¿De qué equipo sos?
Which team do you support?

Soy del Barça.
I support Barça.

¡Ganamos!
We won!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Argentina an hincha is a supporter, and the word comes from the man who used to hinchar, pump up, the leather balls at a club in Montevideo over a century ago: he shouted so loudly for his team that his job became the name for all fans.

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08

¡A PRACTICAR!

ACTIVITIES

1 MATCH THEM UP

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish word or phrase.

1	el partido	☐	A	the goal
2	el gol	☐	B	to train
3	el equipo	☐	C	the national team
4	el portero	☐	D	the match
5	el árbitro	☐	E	to win
6	entrenar	☐	F	the referee
7	la selección	☐	G	the fan
8	el hincha	☐	H	the team
9	la camiseta	☐	I	the shirt
10	ganar	☐	J	the goalkeeper

2 ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

Read each sentence and circle V (true) or F (false).

1. Leo Messi nació en Rosario, Argentina. **V** **F**
2. Messi es diestro y juega de portero. **V** **F**
3. Se mudó a Barcelona a los trece años. **V** **F**
4. Argentina ganó el Mundial de 2022. **V** **F**
5. Un equipo de fútbol tiene quince jugadores en el campo. **V** **F**
6. El Balón de Oro es un premio al mejor jugador del mundo. **V** **F**

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3 LA NOCHE DEL MUNDIAL

Complete the report with the words from the box.

partido	goles	final	penales	capitán	copa	gente	calle

El 18 de diciembre de 2022 Argentina jugó la _____ del Mundial contra Francia. Fue el _____ más emocionante en años: Messi marcó dos _____ y el resultado acabó tres a tres. Argentina ganó en los _____. El _____ levantó la _____ delante de todos. Esa noche la _____ salió a la _____ en todo el país.

4 SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

Write the word used in Argentina next to the one used in Spain.

- **el campo** → _____
- **el balón** → _____
- **la portería** → _____
- **el portero** → _____
- **el entrenador** → _____
- **las botas** → _____
- **chutar** → _____
- **el aficionado** → _____

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5 SOPA DE LETRAS

Find the 12 words. They go across → or down ↓.

J	U	P	J	N	M	A	P	M	F	V	C
M	D	R	B	G	J	E	H	N	N	R	O
U	P	C	R	O	S	A	R	I	O	F	P
N	E	P	C	A	N	C	H	A	N	T	A
D	L	I	E	O	T	I	M	E	S	S	I
I	O	O	M	N	H	E	C	F	E	F	H
A	T	H	A	R	U	F	I	J	A	U	E
L	A	E	Q	U	I	P	O	O	T	T	Z
M	V	U	C	A	P	I	T	A	N	B	U
A	R	Q	U	E	R	O	L	E	S	O	R
V	G	O	L	E	S	B	P	T	N	L	D
N	N	N	D	R	N	B	G	C	G	P	O

MESSI

ROSARIO

FUTBOL

PELOTA

CANCHA

ARQUERO

GOLES

EQUIPO

MUNDIAL

CAPITAN

ZURDO

COPA

6 PUT IT IN ORDER

Unscramble each sentence and write it on the line.

1. **hora / ¿A / qué / partido / el / es**

_____

2. **final / Marcó / goles / en / la / dos**

_____

3. **Barça / del / Soy**

_____

4. **el / penalti / El / portero / paró**

_____

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7 TU EQUIPO

Write four or five sentences about football and you: which team you support, which position you play or would like to play, who your favourite player is and why, and the best match you've ever seen. Use at least six words from this resource.

Try: Soy del... Juego de... Mi jugador favorito es... porque... El mejor partido que vi fue...

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ANSWERS

1 · MATCH THEM UP

1–D, 2–A, 3–H, 4–J, 5–F, 6–B, 7–C, 8–G, 9–I, 10–E

2 · ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

1 V, 2 F, 3 V, 4 V, 5 F, 6 V

3 · LA NOCHE DEL MUNDIAL

1. final, 2. partido, 3. goles, 4. penales, 5. capitán, 6. copa, 7. gente, 8. calle

4 · SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

el campo → la cancha; el balón → la pelota; la portería → el arco; el portero → el arquero; el entrenador → el técnico; las botas → los botines; chutar → patear; el aficionado → el hincha

6 · PUT IT IN ORDER

¿A qué hora es el partido? · Marcó dos goles en la final. · Soy del Barça. · El portero paró el penalti.

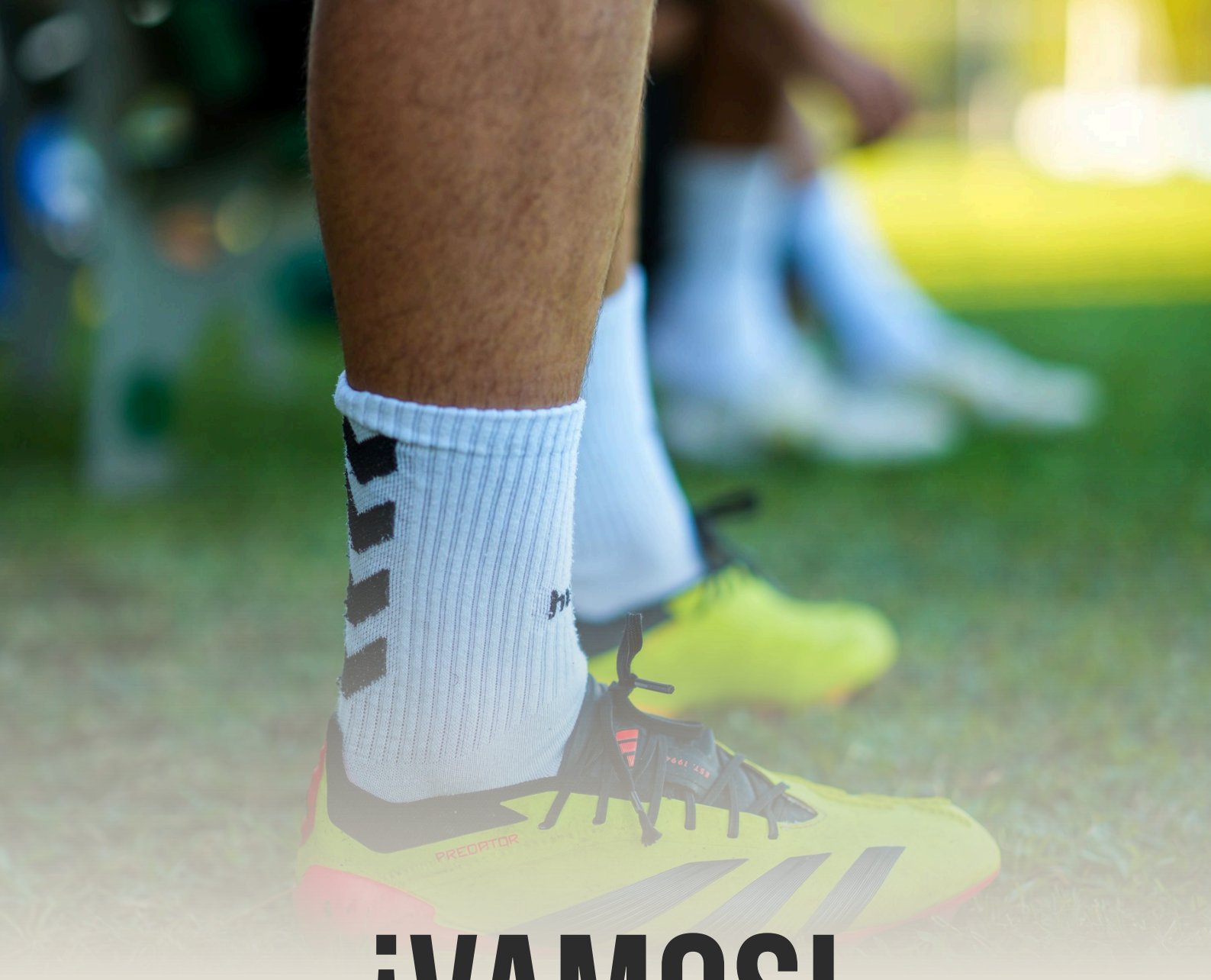
7 · TU EQUIPO

Any answer that uses six words from this resource is perfect. If you can, say it out loud at match speed: football Spanish is meant to be shouted.

5 · SOPA DE LETRAS

J	U	P	J	N	M	A	P	M	F	V	C
M	D	R	B	G	J	E	H	N	N	R	O
U	P	C	R	O	S	A	R	I	O	F	P
N	E	P	C	A	N	C	H	A	N	T	A
D	L	I	E	O	T	I	M	E	S	S	I
I	O	O	M	N	H	E	C	F	E	F	H
A	T	H	A	R	U	F	I	J	A	U	E
L	A	E	Q	U	I	P	O	O	T	T	Z
M	V	U	C	A	P	I	T	A	N	B	U
A	R	Q	U	E	R	O	L	E	S	O	R
V	G	O	L	E	S	B	P	T	N	L	D
N	N	N	D	R	N	B	G	C	G	P	O

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¡VAMOS!

SEE YOU SOON

A small boy from Rosario, a left foot and a lot of training. You now have the words to watch a match in Spanish, argue about the referee and celebrate properly. ¡Vamos!

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SPANISH

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